

Facilitator Guide

Healthcare Future Thinking, 2000 to 2025

Three clusters: Obesity & Weight-Loss Care, Pandemic/Public Health/Vaccines, and Mental Health. Part 1 shows where things stood in 2000 through real signals that could plausibly have gone either way. Part 2 shows what actually happened by 2025. Two unrelated "noise" items are mixed into Part 1 on purpose, real things that got attention but went nowhere.

Part 1: 2000, Where Things Stood

Cluster by cluster, before anyone knew how it would turn out

1. Obesity & Weight-Loss Care

Doctors have nothing to offer except "eat less, move more." Within twenty years, new drugs will turn obesity into a treatable condition.

- Following a 1997 consultation, the WHO formally labels obesity a global epidemic in its 2000 report, citing rising rates in rich and poor countries alike.
- Confidence in pharmaceutical fixes is collapsing after the diet drug fen-phen was pulled from markets worldwide in 1997 over heart valve damage, even as demand for a real answer keeps growing.
- The low-carbohydrate Atkins diet's popularity has exploded, with sales climbing fast enough that bookstores can't keep it in stock.
- A small but growing number of researchers argue obesity should be treated as a chronic disease, against the mainstream view that it's a lifestyle failure.
- Demand for bariatric surgery in Canada is outpacing hospital capacity, and wait times keep stretching longer.
- UK childhood obesity has roughly doubled over the past decade, officials say, blaming more processed food and less outdoor play.
- Japan's obesity rate remains under 5 percent, far below North America's, which researchers tie to traditional diet and portion sizes.

2. Pandemic, Public Health & Vaccines

Canada has no national outbreak agency. Within decades, a global pandemic will prove a long-ignored vaccine idea right.

- SARS cases in Toronto climb daily through early 2003, reaching 438 suspected cases and 44 deaths before containment.
- Pressure has built for years for a single national public health agency, as outbreak response stays split between Ottawa and the provinces.

- Katalin Karikó, a Hungarian-American scientist, has had her mRNA research funding rejected repeatedly, but keeps refining the idea anyway.
- Officials warn that emergency-readiness funding spikes after a crisis grabs headlines, then fades until the next one hits.
- Childhood vaccination rates and public trust in health agencies are both near record highs.
- The WHO launches a Global Outbreak Alert and Response Network this year, linking labs and health agencies worldwide.
- The UN Security Council formally declares HIV/AIDS a threat to international peace and security, the first time it has treated a health crisis this way.

3. Mental Health

Canada has no national mental health strategy and most people stay quiet about therapy. Within two decades, that silence breaks.

- The WHO dedicates its entire 2001 World Health Report to mental health for the first time, calling it a leading and growing cause of disability.
- Canada has no national mental health agency in 2000, leaving funding and approach entirely up to each province.
- SSRI prescriptions have climbed steadily through the 1990s across Canada and most wealthy countries.
- Surveyed teenagers say most wouldn't tell classmates they were seeing a therapist, fearing judgment.
- Mental health coverage under most plans is far thinner than physical health coverage, with strict visit limits.
- The Royal College of Psychiatrists launches "Changing Minds," a five-year UK campaign to challenge mental illness stigma.
- Mental health related sick leave is rising across European and North American workplaces, though benefits still don't treat it like a physical injury.

Noise (no cluster)

Real attention-getters in 2000 that never connected to the three clusters above.

- Hospitals race to test every computer system before the Y2K bug potentially scrambles records at midnight.
- Anti-aging clinics offering human growth hormone injections promise more energy and younger skin for a steep monthly fee.

Part 2: 2025, What Actually Happened

Confirmed outcomes for the same three clusters. Use this to check predictions against reality.

1. Obesity & Weight-Loss Care

Worldwide adult obesity has more than doubled since 1990. Over 1 billion people globally now live with obesity, the epidemic the WHO warned about only accelerated.

GLP-1 drugs like Ozempic and Wegovy reversed decades of distrust in pharmaceutical fixes.

About 10 million Americans take one, and the global market is worth more than \$80 billion a year.

In 2020, Obesity Canada redefined obesity as a chronic disease in its national guidelines. Only Alberta formally recognizes it, so most Canadians still can't get GLP-1s covered.

Bariatric surgery wait times in Canada remain long, with surgical programs now also competing for resources against GLP-1 demand.

The Atkins-style low-carb craze faded within a decade, overtaken almost entirely by drug-based solutions.

UK childhood obesity kept climbing through the 2010s. In April 2018, the UK introduced a sugary drinks tax, one of the first of its kind; many countries have since followed, though obesity has kept climbing almost everywhere regardless.

2. Pandemic, Public Health & Vaccines

Canada's national public health agency, built in the years after SARS, became the backbone of the country's COVID-19 response in 2020.

The mRNA technology Karikó couldn't get funded built COVID-19 vaccines in under a year. She shared the 2023 Nobel Prize in Medicine for it.

The funding-cycle warning came true almost exactly: public health funding spiked during COVID and has since faded, with pandemic-preparedness grants being cut in multiple countries by 2025.

Public trust in vaccine guidance has fallen sharply. The 2022 Ottawa trucker convoy made Canada's vaccine-mandate backlash global news, even though close to 90% of Canadian truckers were actually vaccinated.

In November 2025, Canada officially lost its measles elimination status after sustained transmission for over a year, with more than 2,300 cases and two deaths.

The WHO's outbreak alert network, launched in 2000, is still active a quarter-century later and was used repeatedly during COVID-19. On March 11, 2020, the WHO formally declared COVID-19 a pandemic.

3. Mental Health

A 2023 national health funding deal named mental health and substance use as a funding priority, building on smaller bilateral agreements that began in 2017.

Antidepressant prescriptions kept climbing, now joined by an entirely new category: therapy delivered through phone apps.

Public stigma has dropped sharply. Celebrities and athletes now routinely discuss their own struggles, once unthinkable for a public figure.

Mental health coverage is still thinner than physical health coverage, even as demand for therapy keeps outpacing it.

Despite less stigma, teen anxiety and depression rates have risen sharply, leading officials in multiple countries to declare a youth mental health crisis by the early 2020s.

England's "Time to Change" anti-stigma campaign shut down in 2021 when government funding wasn't renewed, even though attitude surveys showed it had been working faster than expected.

Workplace mental health is no longer an edge case. A growing number of countries, including France, Ireland, and parts of Canada, now have right-to-disconnect laws.

Noise (resolved)

Neither widely promoted idea held up under scrutiny.

- Hydroxychloroquine was heavily promoted early in COVID-19. Larger trials later found no meaningful benefit.
- Ivermectin gained a large online following in 2021 as an unproven COVID-19 treatment. Health agencies found no solid evidence it worked.

Short-form source: [steep_signal_bank_2000.md](#) and [steep_outcomes_2025.md](#). Long-form versions with newspaper articles, forum threads, blog posts, and tweets: [steep_signal_bank_2000_expanded.md](#) and [steep_outcomes_2025_expanded.md](#).